



THAROOR MAY END UP EMBARRASSING SONIA WHO BACKED HIM EARLIER

his own books lest it be misconstrued.

For all that, much of the controversy is to do with a clash of styles. In the South Block, junior ministers keep their silence if they want to keep their jobs. Tharoor is cut from a different cloth and comes from a different culture and that is the crux of the problem. "Having come from the rarified atmosphere of the UN he needed a little time to adjust to functioning in a political set-up, but his frequent infractions and serial offending indicates a deeper character flaw," says former secretary in the MEA K.C. Singh.

A major fallout of the controversies surrounding Tharoor has been that there has been a needless distraction from pressing issues like managing a robust policy on Africa, Latin

RUBBING IT IN

He is accused of plugging a controversial book

■ After Tharoor became a minister of state, copies of three of his books were bought in July 2009 by the MEA's Public Diplomacy Division at a cost of 3,27,924. The division is tasked with promoting the image of India abroad.

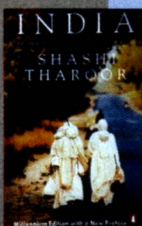
■ According to MEA records, the financial clearance was obtained in August and books were dispatched in December 2009 to all 150 Indian missions and consulates.

■ Apart from *India: From Midnight to the Millennium*, Tharoor's other books, *The Great Indian Novel* (150 copies) and a coffee table book (200 copies) co-authored by him were also bought by the MEA.

■ Tharoor denies any impropriety, says it was written in 1997 and copies may have been bought by the MEA before he became a minister.

America and the Gulf, that are under his charge. Even though there is a clear demarcation of duties in a protocol-driven ministry, Tharoor has continued to speak out on subjects which do not come under his jurisdiction, including on relations with Pakistan. Tharoor, however, defends himself forcefully. "Any comment I have ever made on foreign policy has been based on thorough briefings by the responsible officers, often conducted specifically to prepare ministers for such questions. While the mos have specific allocations of duties, it would be absurd for them to be ignorant of major developments in the country's external relations. I answered six questions in the Lok Sabha on Afghanistan even though it is not among my officially allocated countries. Should that also be considered 'overstepping' or 'unprofessionalism'?" he asked.

Tharoor's stint as a minister seems a classic case of a rookie getting too big for his boots too early. Tharoor blended well with the Page 3 chatterati in Delhi, but his style created adjustment problems within India's grand



PROPRIETY DEMANDED THAT HE SHOULD HAVE ADVISED THE MINISTRY AGAINST BUYING HIS BOOKS FOR MISSIONS ABROAD.

■ *India: From Midnight to the Millennium*, published in 1997, portrays the Congress and the Gandhi family in a poor light.

Some excerpts:

"Mrs Gandhi ... had no real vision or programme beyond the expedient campaign slogan."

"Had he lived, as one aspiring prime minister among many, Rajiv might well have presided over the terminal decline of the dynasty."

"Sonia, the inheritor of his legacy was in Cambridge to study English as a second language, not political philosophy."

old party and the government set-up, where he is still considered a newcomer. He comes across a man in a hurry to do too much too soon and trips up too often for comfort. Former foreign secretary Lalit Mansingh says, "He is an articulate person and is an asset the Government must use properly. There are clear lines of demarcation between a cabinet minister and a minister of state. He must be clearly told on what he can comment and what are the areas he should avoid."

Tharoor must now tread with caution for the next tweet may well be his last—as minister of state. ■